



Creative Photography 1

OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE · FAMILY COURSE OVERVIEW · GRADES 9–12 · ELECTIVE

~4¼ hrs per week · 50 min/day, M–F

About this overview. This document is an example of how the course might be taught. More photographs and projects are approved for this course than appear here, so scholars may see some variation in works studied and projects from course to course, and between the live school and On-Demand. Each teacher also leans into their own strengths and passions; the structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

Creative Photography introduces photography as an art form and a way of seeing. Building on centuries of visual tradition, scholars learn how cameras and photographic techniques extend the human ability to observe, compose, and express. They master the fundamental mechanics of the camera — lens and shutter — and learn to use composition, light, and color as tools for clear visual communication. Through both digital and traditional processes, scholars create images that reflect careful observation and intentional choices, using VR and AI tools to explore, refine, and present their work. The deepest skill the course teaches is recognizing what is worth seeing — and photographing.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

1 Camera Mechanics (foundation)

How lens and shutter actually work, and how to control them on purpose.

3 Light and Color (all year)

Reading and shaping light and color as the photographer's raw material.

5 Seeing as an Artist (all year)

Careful observation, intentional choices, and the visual tradition photographs belong to.

2 Composition (all year)

Framing, balance, and emphasis: arranging what the viewer sees.

4 Digital and Traditional Processes (strand)

Creating and refining images across photographic processes.

6 Presenting the Work (all year)

Refining and presenting images — with VR and AI tools among the means — into a growing OneDrive portfolio.

A TYPICAL WEEK

- Optima art courses run on a two-week cycle.
- Week 1: look closely at real photographs and masterworks, learn the cycle's concept and technique, and complete shooting exercises.
- Week 2: create the cycle's finished photograph or series and submit it with a short artist statement — every finished work is signed.
- Critique uses the Elements of Art and Principles of Design as its shared vocabulary.

TIME COMMITMENT

250 minutes / week

≈ 50 minutes a day, Monday–Friday

- Daily lesson, shooting practice, and review fill most of the scheduled minutes.
- Finished-piece weeks may run longer as images are refined and presented.

WHAT SCHOLARS NEED

- A digital camera — a phone camera works to start.
- A computer with reliable internet and access to Canvas.
- Microsoft 365 and OneDrive (provided to every scholar) for the photo portfolio.

On-Demand (asynchronous). Scholars move through the course at their own pace, with due dates to keep the year on track. An Optima teacher is available throughout for support, feedback, and grading.

Live school. Live-school scholars take this same course on Optima's VR campus with a teacher and classmates, meeting daily on the school's schedule.